

MORE QUESTIONS THAN ANSWERS

India's pointless run at the Asian Cup ends with three losses and no goals, **raising concerns** about coach Igor Stimac's leadership and the team's future.

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India entered the AFC Asian Cup 2023 with the hope of achieving an underdog success story.

Two weeks later, it exited the tournament with three losses in as many games, zero goals, and zero points, as coach Igor Stimac rummaged for excuses.

The Blue Tigers started their campaign with a 0-2 loss to Australia, the only match it showed serious

spine — stifling the Socceroos in the first half and almost scoring from a Sunil Chhetri header.

But Jackson Irvine's goal pushed them back into a defensive mindset, and a slip-up in that department had Jordan Bos score his first international goal to double the lead.

During its game against Uzbekistan, India looked like a bunch of schoolboys on tour for the first 20 minutes, which ultimately cost them the game. By half-time, Srejko Katanec's team had scored three

goals, almost guaranteeing India's disqualification from the tournament.

Hector Cuper, who had taken Egypt to the FIFA World Cup after 28 years, put the final nail in the coffin

Withering challenge: After nearly five years under Stimac, India's rank has fallen another spot — after rising to 99th for a month — to 102 in the last rankings and is expected to fall further after the AFC Asian Cup. AP

